



The 'WORKING' CLASS

An eclectic mix of students provides the right atmosphere for intellectual stimulation

Traditionally in India, business schools have never imposed any restriction for entry based on work experience for the Post Graduate Programmes (PGPs). The norm globally, on the other hand, is that work experience is either mandatory or given so much weightage in the admissions process that the balance is tilted in favour of those with experience.

There are a number of reasons for this. First and foremost is the societal reason. We as a country are more culturally attuned to "completing" education at one go, so a first degree is usually followed by a second one almost immediately.

Earlier, businesses usually had well developed internal training programmes where they admitted students from all backgrounds, groomed them for a year or two and slowly brought them into "managerial" roles. Today, recruiters have almost done away with these long-duration training programmes and are not looking at plain graduates to hone their skills at work and learn on the job. They are looking for managers who can slip into the roles immediately and are therefore looking at management qualifications.

Another fact is that most of the top business schools of the country run two types of management courses—the PGP and the Executive MBA. Both these courses have their own specifics and it is the executive programme where there is a minimum requirement of work experience.

Globally, the courses are usually not differentiated on basis of work experience. The Executive MBA in international business schools typically refers to weekend programmes, distance learning or e-learning courses with periodic contact modules thrown in. Mid-career programmes are usually few and far between and typically are not long-term programmes. Historically, the genesis of global MBA is that it began as an in-house programme, evolved slowly into a part-time course and finally took the shape of a full-time management degree.

One of the important reasons for not making work experience mandatory for PGP programmes is to have a mix of fresh and experienced students. This eclectic mix provides the right

atmosphere for intellectual stimulation. Freshers are more inquisitive by nature and are more adaptive to management theory and principles while experienced students are more objective and bring practical reasoning to discussions. This leads to healthy discussions and debates amongst students and teachers and also brings new ideas to the table.

The quality of students emerging out of top business schools in India has never been doubted. In fact, the exploits of students from the seven Indian Institute of Management (IIMs) across the corporate world globally speaks volumes about the calibre of these students. In fact, today most global organisations of repute have students from India in key functions.

Yes, there has been an ongoing debate regarding a minimum criterion of number of years of experience being made a pre-requisite for students seeking admission into business schools in India. The thought process is that an experienced student will be "mentally" more mature to grasp the finer nuances of the corporate ethos if he or she has been through it. But we have never felt the need to impose artificial barriers restricting the entry of talent. As it is, the entry system into the premier business schools itself is one of the toughest in the world and this system tends to pick only the brightest.

However, if you see across campuses in India, including the IIM campus at Lucknow, the trends have been changing with more and more students with prior work experience joining in. You will find that the average years of work experience are increasing over the years in most campuses. This is in itself a healthy sign and shows the maturing of students wanting a management degree without the imposition of any curbs.

It is my belief that this process of natural elimination, due to the increasing number of students with prior work experience competing for management education, will continue. This course of action is certainly preferable to making work experience compulsory for admission to PGP in business schools across the country.

The writer is Director, Indian Institute of Management-Lucknow



SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com